



▲ GYEOGBOKGUNG PALACE

Gyeongbokgung was the largest and most important of five royal palaces built in the city of Seoul, then known as Hanseong, during the Joseon Dynasty. Built in 1395, the palace was home to Joseon kings as well as the government. It was destroyed during the Imjin War with Japan, but was restored and rebuilt in the 19th and 20th centuries.

FACT

Joseon Korea had a strict class system. People were born into one of four classes—*yangban* (landowner), *chungin* (middle class), *sangmin* (commoner), or *cheonmin* (lowborn).

SEJONG THE GREAT

Sejong the Great (reigned 1418–1450) was the fourth Joseon ruler. He created the Hangul script that made it easier for everyone to read and write Korean. He also promoted science and technology, which led to many inventions.



Korea's Joseon Dynasty

The Joseon Dynasty ruled over the Korean Peninsula (modern-day North Korea and South Korea) from 1392–1910. During this time, Korea went through a golden age of culture and learning as well as significant social change.

From 57 BCE until 668 CE, ancient Korea was ruled by three kingdoms. Then, one of the three kingdoms, Silla, gained control over the entire peninsula, and stayed in power until 935. The kingdom then briefly split, before being reunified under the Goryeo Kingdom for a period of 470 years.

The Goryeo Kingdom was overthrown by General Yi Seong-gye, who named his dynasty Joseon and became its first king, taking the title Taejo. The new dynasty expanded its boundaries and moved its capital from Kaesong (in modern-day North Korea) to the city of Hanseong

(modern-day Seoul, the capital of South Korea). Over the next 500 years, the Joseon Kingdom went through great changes. Neo-Confucianism—a philosophy based on the traditional teachings of the Chinese philosopher Confucius—was promoted, and a strict social class system was put in place. The period also saw many important advancements in literature, science, and astronomy.

After several invasions from China and Japan in the 16th and 17th centuries, the kingdom entered a period of isolation for nearly 200 years, and declined in the late 19th century as Japan gradually took over control of Korea.



The wooden dragon head hid a cannon or burner that released fire or smoke.

◀ TURTLE SHIP

The geobukseon (turtle ship) was designed by the Korean admiral Yi Sun-sin in the 16th century. These armored warships had a protective roof, like a turtle shell, which was covered with spikes. They were also equipped with cannons.

Powered by up to 70 oarspeople, the ship could turn quickly and achieve bursts of high speed.